

THE SEMINAR FAIL

What idiot would pay \$50,000 to attend a seminar? Many do. This is a common question at the Fastlane Forum. So-and-so is offering a three-day seminar on real estate investment for \$50,000. Should I buy it? What? Are you a smoking crack? Do you know what you're buying? Let me tell you. You're paying \$50,000 for someone to explain a book that's found at the bookstore for 19 bucks.

A \$50,000 seminar is exploitation of what we producers know: *People are lazy*. People want it handed to them. People don't want to read and connect the dots; they want it done for them. People want to be steered. They want someone to drive their vehicle. People want events, not process, and what better event than a \$50,000 seminar!

Seminars can be great for education, but it has to be the right seminar, which is affordable and given by producers and experienced experts, not by professional, career public speakers. Most high-dollar seminars are well-orchestrated marketing machines tailored to extract every dollar from your wallet. Most cheap seminars are daylong up-sells to a more expensive seminar. And those well-suited presenters? They suffer the typical Paradox of Practice: rich from public speaking to millions but not rich from what they teach.

A member of the Fastlane Forum reflected on her recent seminar experience with a popular book guru:

First, you won't be "allowed" to network. If you were allowed to network then people would find out quicker that the seminar is just one giant sales pitch for a larger, more expensive seminar to the tune of \$50,000. Second, you won't learn a damn thing, except that you should have listened to your gut and not gone. There really is a sucker born every minute. Amazing how people have nothing in the bank but can come up with \$50K just for the hope of something better. And finally, there is a segment in the seminar where they have you increase the balance on your credit cards, because after all, the rich make money and the poor earn it. So then everyone goes and increases their balances, and then guess what—they hit you with the purchase price of anywhere from \$16K to \$50K, depending on how "serious" you are. Ridiculous? Apparently not, because people go rushing to the back of the room like cattle to slaughter, credit cards in hand. They leave with a nervous sense of self-satisfaction and a cute little sticker on their shirt that says "I invest in myself."

A \$50,000 oil change is as shocking as a \$50,000 seminar. Good seminars are under \$1,000 and are given by respectable experts, practitioners, and seminar firms. Good seminars are educational and don't come at the price of a new Cadillac Escalade. Bad seminars are hyped, high-pressure, and exploitative. Bad seminars are about making money and not about helping you.